

Several years went by before the public grasped what the Wrights were doing; people were so convinced that flying was impossible that most of those who saw them flying about Dayton [Ohio] in 1905 decided that what they had seen must be some trick without significance—somewhat as most people today would regard a demonstration of, say, telepathy. It was not until May, 1908—nearly four and a half years after the Wright's first flight—that experienced reporters were sent to observe what they were doing, experienced editors gave full credence to these reporters' excited dispatches, and the world at last woke up to the fact that human flight had been successfully accomplished.

Even after people caught on to the plane's wonder, they underestimated it for years.

First it was seen mainly as a military weapon. Then a rich person's toy. Then, perhaps, used to transport a few people.

The Washington Post wrote in 1909: "There will never be such a thing as commercial aerial freighters. Freight will continue to drag its slow weight across the patient earth." The first cargo plane took off five months later.

Now compare that slow, years-long awakening to becoming optimistic about the airplane to how quickly people pay attention to drivers of pessimism, like a corporate bankruptcy.

Or a major war.

Or a plane *crash*. Some of the first mentions of the Wright's plane came in 1908 when an Army Lieutenant named Thomas Selfridge was killed during a demonstration flight.⁶²

Growth is driven by compounding, which always takes time. Destruction is driven by single points of failure, which can happen in seconds, and loss of confidence, which can happen in an instant.

It's easier to create a narrative around pessimism because the story pieces tend to be fresher and more recent. Optimistic narratives require looking at a long stretch of history and developments, which people tend to forget and take more effort to piece together.

Consider the progress of medicine. Looking at the last year will do you little good. Any single decade won't do much better. But looking at the last 50 years will show something extraordinary. For example, the age-adjusted death rate per capita from heart disease has declined more than 70% since 1965, according to the National Institute of Health.⁶³ A 70% decline in heart-disease death is enough to save something like half a million